

The role of women in the church has been debated. This study examines Scripture to determine what roles women may have.

The conclusion proposed is: Women may serve in any role except that of elder. Women may teach based on competency and ability.

1 Corinthians 14:34–35 teaches that women should be silent in the churches. However, this cannot mean absolute silence because women pray and prophesy (1 Cor 11:5). Therefore, the silence must be situational. The likely issue is disorder, including interruptions and public questioning.

1 Timothy 2:11–12 states: “I do not permit a woman to teach or to exercise authority over a man...” Quietness refers to demeanor, not absolute silence. Teaching and authority are linked, indicating that women are not to teach in a way that assumes authority over men.

The term for authority (authentein) may imply domineering or usurping authority. Therefore, the restriction may apply specifically to improper or forceful authority rather than all forms of teaching.

The context of 1 Timothy includes false teaching and disorder in Ephesus. This suggests that the restriction may address specific issues related to untrained or incorrect teaching.

Paul references creation: “Adam was formed first.” This may reflect complementarity rather than hierarchy, emphasizing relational order rather than universal restriction.

Eve’s deception is noted, which may indicate a situational concern about vulnerability to false teaching in that context.

In Acts 18:26, Priscilla, along with Aquila, instructed Apollos. This demonstrates that women can participate in teaching men.

In 1 Corinthians 11, women pray and prophesy publicly. This indicates that women were active participants in the life of the church.

Elders are responsible for teaching and doctrinal oversight (Titus 1:9). Since women are not elders, they do not hold governing authority, but may still teach in other capacities.

Teaching may be exercised according to gifting and competency. Women may contribute through teaching, instructing, and sharing knowledge in appropriate contexts.

Questions raised include whether women may teach Bible classes, instruct mixed groups, or share knowledge publicly. The position affirms that such participation is generally permissible.

Final conclusion: Women may teach, instruct, and speak in mixed settings, but may not serve as elders.